

Excellent comments. I'm glad you discovered effective study methods early in your life. The benefits are extensive.
Thanks Kyle.
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A Quest to Improve Life Skills

At the start of fifth grade, I tested into an accelerated learning environment called The Challenge Center. There, I received faster-paced teaching methods and more inclusive topics than the average elementary student in Sioux Falls, SD. Additionally, being in that group guided the rest of my pre-college schooling, leading me to accelerated classes in middle school and twelve AP courses in high school. Despite performing better academically than most of my classmates, I was doing so with less effort. At the time, I didn't think I was doing anything particularly unique. However, looking back, I can identify two main study techniques I used that allowed me to learn new information efficiently and effectively.

First, I used spaced learning. Spacing out study sessions has been shown to dramatically increase learning, particularly in the long term memory of a subject (Carpenter & Agarwal). For example, in high school, it was not uncommon for me to review the same topic two to three times a day. I didn't space out my studying intentionally, but the school day forced me into short time periods before school and between classes. I had a routine of studying with Quizlet, an online study platform with written answer flashcards, every morning before the start of my first class. These consistent ten to fifteen minute sessions proved to be very effective for studying Spanish vocabulary, anatomy terms, and AP Biology definitions. Spaced learning allowed me to spend less time studying and learn information in a way that enabled me to recall it later. However, while spaced learning was an influential part of my study habits, more effective was my use of retrieval practice.

Retrieval practice is a term that I have been familiar with for years in practice, though not by that name. For years, I've been forcing myself to come up with information on my own before I check my work with a reference. While listening to a podcast by CGP Grey, "Hello Internet," he claimed that someone who didn't answer a question out loud would simply agree with the answer once they heard it and think, "I knew that." When in reality, because they hadn't solidified their opinion, they may not have. I connected with this argument and ensured that while I was studying I wrote or voiced my answers aloud before checking a key. I called it active recall because I felt like I was doing my best to actively recall information rather than passively reviewing it. Utilizing retrieval practice certainly made my study sessions more efficient and effective.

Despite the proven advantages of these methods, I didn't use them because I knew they had been tested. I feel lucky to have stumbled upon these techniques right away rather than wasting time creating a beautiful notebook, highlighting textbooks, or re-reading chapters. I didn't intentionally choose study methods that were scientifically proven, but I stuck with them because they worked. I plan to continue to use spaced learning and retrieval practice by forcing myself to decide on an answer before checking my work and by splitting study sessions into short and intense periods. By practicing these methods, I hope to continue to study effectively, an important life skill. Another crucial life skill is one's ability to be professional.

Professionalism is the extent of one's ability to display confidence, arrive on time, and complete required tasks effectively and consistently. Incorporating these aspects into one's life takes significant effort and respect for others. Someone's professionalism is a product of the trust they build between someone else and themselves. Trust is built by dressing for the situation, consistently arriving on time, and displaying mastery of job-related skills. Ultimately, aspects of professionalism prove that one is consistently dependable and trustworthy. While I found effective study techniques on my own, I can thank my parents for my professional

manner. I'm particularly proud of my punctuality and dedication to completing tasks entirely and properly.

I do my best to adhere to many professional qualities, but there are aspects of professionalism that I am still improving. I am still growing in my confidence, particularly when speaking in public situations. While often forgotten, one's vocal image is just as important as their physical one when it comes to displaying confidence. Additionally, I am still developing work related skills that prove I can do my part in a group and provide value. I'm aware of Data Science tools like SQL, SDLC, and GitHub, and I will look into these tools more intensely as I get closer to finishing my education.

The ability to study effectively and be professional are skills that I will likely never perfect but will always continue to improve. I am aware of how these skills can make the difference between two individuals who have the same education. As a result, I plan to continue to use the study skills I have and the professional characteristics I possess to the best of my ability. Additionally, I am improving my public speaking and work related skills to make myself a more professional individual.

Works Cited

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